

KR$NA's new album features collaborations with friends such as Raftaar and Seedhe Maut

MUSIC ▼

A MAN OF LETTERS

The songs of rapper KR$NA stand out for their lyrical wordplay, as can be heard on his new mixtape

When KR$NA's new mixtape, *Yours Truly*, reached No. 1 on Apple Music's Top Albums chart within 24 hours of release last month, the hip-hop star felt validated. He made the record at a point in his life when he was unsure of his next move. "For a while, I was like, 'What can I do that will be liked [by the public] and satisfy me artistically?'" says KR$NA of the collection that's been put out in partnership with Mass Appeal, the label co-founded by one of his idols, American MC Nas.

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He had a breakthrough after listening to a 2015 episode of VOTP, the Indian hip-hop podcast hosted by rappers Bobkat and Enkore, on which they discussed how he's frequently been under-appreciated. Says KR$NA, "[I thought,] okay, I wasn't crazy to think people weren't giving me my props."

Consequently, *Yours Truly*, which includes excerpts from that episode, became a vehicle for him to write about things he has never addressed, on songs such as the reflective 'Nothing To Prove'. "I have never on a track said that this is the way I felt about what others were thinking about me," he says. The mixtape also takes a swipe at the music industry where labels are notorious for treating upcoming artists like potential products rather than creative professionals. KR$NA says his career took off after he met Ankit Khanna, who signed him to his label Kalamkaar Music in 2017.

Today, KR$NA is among India's best-known rappers, lauded for his wordplay. He partially attributes this skill to being surrounded by newspapers and magazines while growing up, thanks to his grandfather. That habit of voracious reading has manifested itself in the form of the many references he drops in his bars, and is particularly prominent on *Yours Truly*, which features collaborations with friends such as Raftaar, Badshah, Seedhe Maut and Yashraj as well as international talents like Japan's Awich and the UK's Aitch. Notable by their absence are diss tracks, which he has had success with in the past. "Those listeners are there for the drama, not because they enjoy listening to you on a sad day," says KR$NA. ■

—Amit Gurbaxani